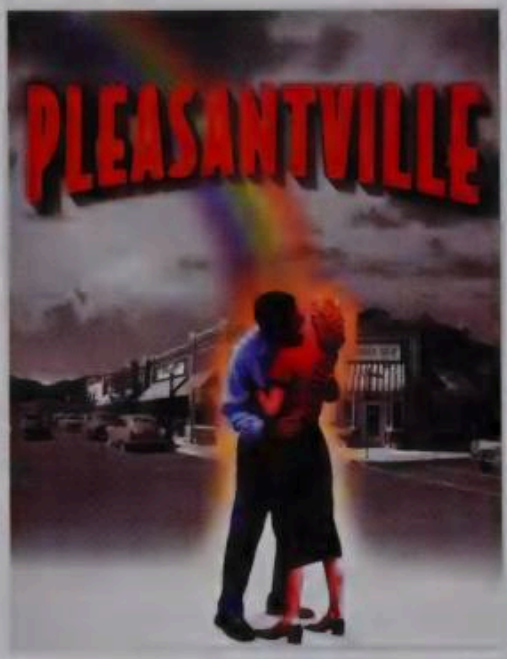
the hero's surname is Darcy in both stories. In case anyone missed the point, Colin Firth, who had played Mr Darcy in the 1995 BBC mini-series of *Pride and Prejudice*, was cast as Mark Darcy in the film.

How films are promoted: film posters

Film posters: giving information

Film posters are hard to ignore – they are large, they are eye-catching and they are often intriguing. How well do they communicate information about the genre, characters and events in the films? Look at posters **8** to **11**, showing films featuring movie star Reese Witherspoon. What genre would you expect each film to be? In what different ways is Reese Witherspoon presented in these posters?



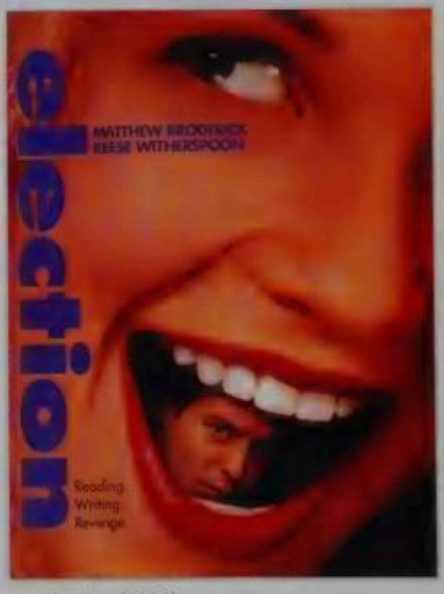
8 *Pleasantville* (1998)



9 *The Importance of Being Earnest* (2002)



10 *Fear* (1996)



11 *Election* (1999)

ACTIVITY 15

In pairs, use the information on the posters, both in words and pictures, to match these plot summaries to the film titles in posters **8** to **11**.

A Nicole discovers that her 'perfect' boyfriend David has a violent and disturbed side to his character.

B Jennifer and her brother David find themselves trapped in his favourite 1950s soap opera.

C This screen version of Oscar Wilde's play casts Reese as the young sweetheart Cecily in a comedy of manners.

D Tracy wants to be student president and uses some surprising tactics in this comedy film about the world of high-school politics.

Did you find lots of clues on the posters? Posters communicate information by the way the images are presented. The **gesture codes** of the characters instantly signal violent and disturbing events or romantic and comic moments. Other details, such as costume, location and lighting, also help us read the poster's messages.

A key message is the genre of the film. Next, the poster gives clues about the story in the **tag line**. Tag lines can become well known in their own right:

- The science fiction/horror classic *Alien* (1979) had the famous tag line *In space, no one can hear you scream ...*
- *Jaws 2* (1978) had the tag line *Just when you thought it was safe to go back in the water*. This was an intertextual reference to the first film *Jaws* (1975), which had been a huge hit. It reminds the audience of the terror of bathing in shark-infested waters.

ACTIVITY 16

Think of some catchy tag lines for these films:

- *First Victim*: a new monster, part werewolf, part vampire, hits town, looking for his first victim – a teenager.
- *No Way, Baby:* high-school heart-throb Jay is determined not to get tied down in a steady relationship. The high-school babes have other ideas!
- *Triple Deceit*: Detective Pacino is baffled by a series of murders until his new partner gives him some valuable insights. But where does she get her information?

Film posters: promoting stars

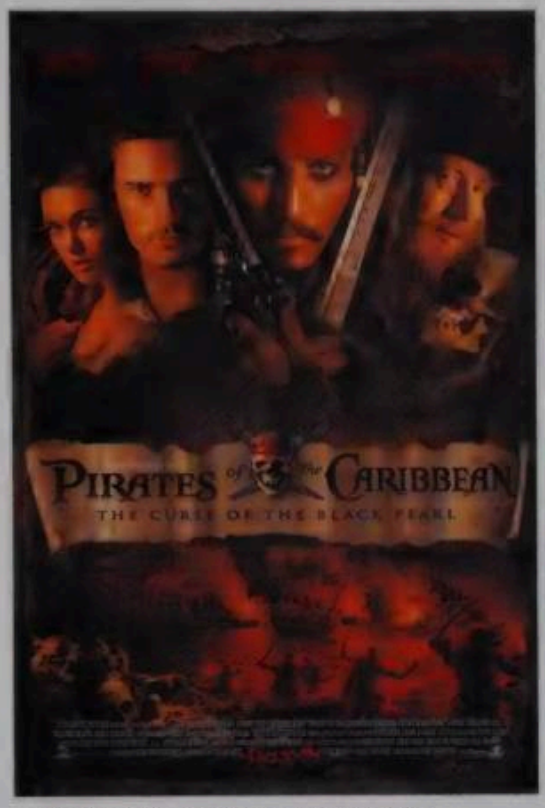
One way a poster can grab people's attention is to show pictures of the film's stars. The more popular the star, the more dominant their image will be in the poster. Stars are said to be 'A' or 'B' list depending on how popular they are. Can you identify the biggest **box-office draw** in each of posters **12** to **15**?

KEY TERMS

Box-office draw a performer whose popularity is likely to make a film successful; they are said to *carry* the film

Gesture code how a media text conveys a message using facial expression or body language

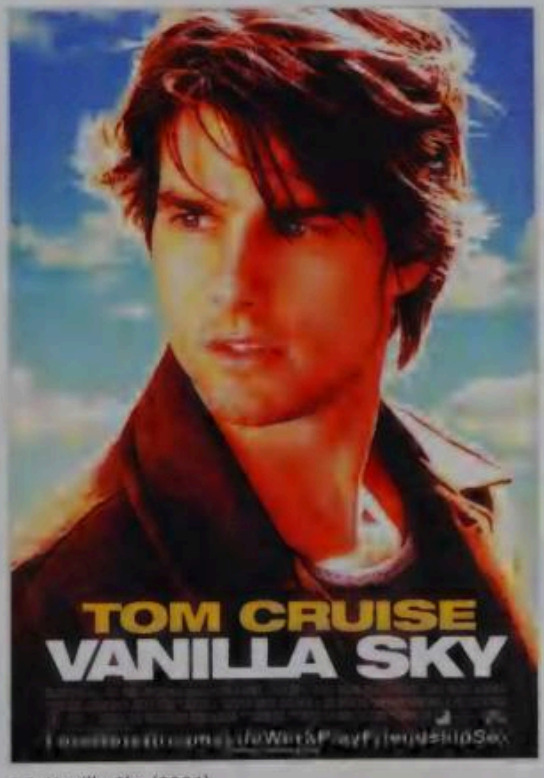
Tag line short, catchy statement on a film poster suggesting the film's content



12 *Pirates of the Caribbean: The Curse of the Black Pearl* (2003)



13 *Titanic* (1997)



14 *Vanilla Sky* (2001)



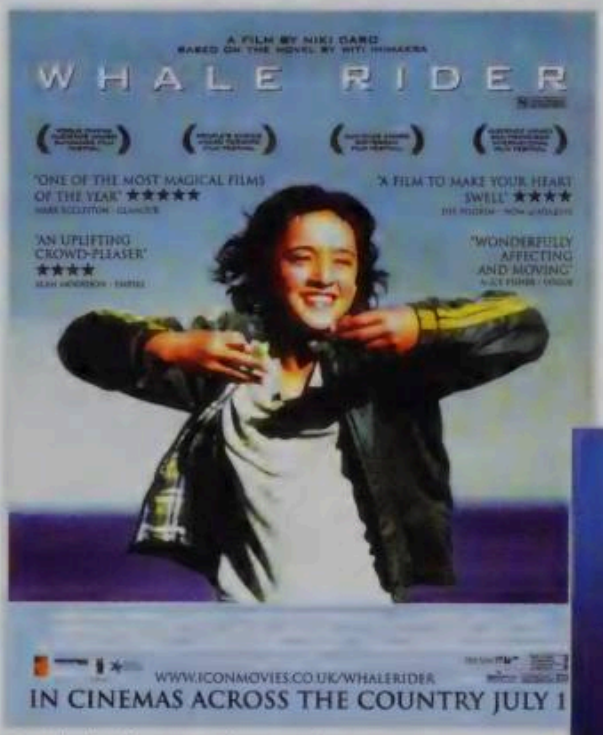
15 *The Hours* (2002)

How could you tell who carried each film? The size and position of the star's name and image are so important that they are part of the star's contract for the film. Big stars try to get their name on the left of the poster and their picture on the right, because these are the most eye-catching positions. Who has these positions in **12**?

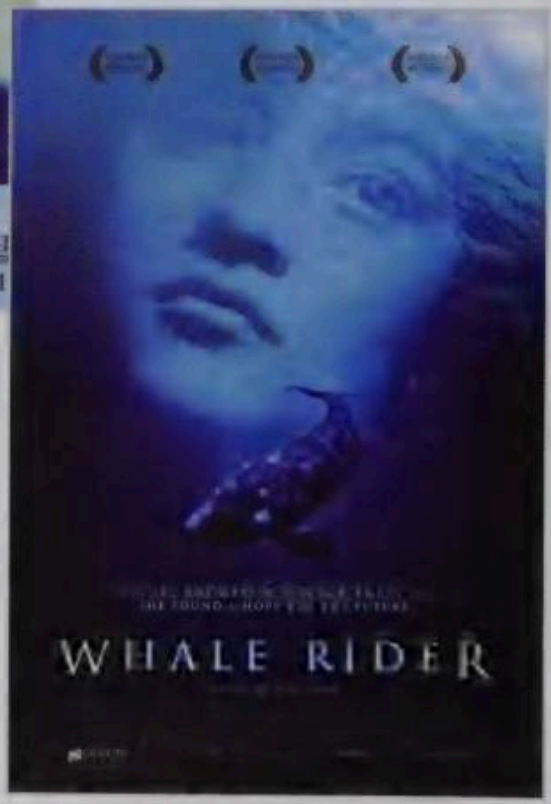
Posters are used to publicise and promote a film when it comes out in the cinema. They may be used again when it is available to rent or, a couple of months later, buy on video or DVD.

Film posters: targeting audiences

Film posters target audiences, and audiences in different parts of the world like different sorts of films. They may be particularly interested in a film set in their own country, and people of different cultures may find different types of films, or different features of the same film, appealing. Although the film remains the same, posters may portray it quite differently in different countries.



16 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the UK



17 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the United States